Adobe Red Rocks AI Innovation Challenge

Comprehensive Problem Discovery & Analysis

Project: 2026 Adobe Red Rocks AI Innovation Challenge

Stakeholder: Who Rocks the House (WRTH) / Utah Red Rocks Gymnastics

Purpose: Identify and evaluate problems across the NIL ecosystem before developing potential solutions.

Problem Classification

- **Confirmed:** Explicitly identified as a problem, goal, or challenge in the kickoff materials.
- **Challenge Objective:** A capability or outcome explicitly requested by the competition, but not necessarily a verified existing problem.
- **Hypothesis:** A potential problem requiring stakeholder research or validation.
- **Design Consideration:** A factor that must be considered when developing a solution.
- **Strategic Tension:** Competing objectives or priorities requiring careful consideration.

1. WRTH — Growth, Funding & Operations

Context: Who Rocks the House (WRTH) aims to expand annual funding from approximately $200K toward $2M while maintaining its athlete-centered, community-focused approach to NIL.

#	Problem	Status
1	Need to grow annual funding from $200K toward $2M	Confirmed
2	Need to convert more fans into financial contributors	Confirmed
3	Need to identify more businesses for NIL partnerships	Confirmed
4	Need compelling offerings or benefits that encourage investment	Confirmed
5	Limited understanding of why potential supporters do not contribute	Hypothesis
6	Difficulty converting one-time donors into recurring supporters	Hypothesis
7	Difficulty identifying high-potential donors or sponsors	Hypothesis

8	Dependence on manually managing sponsor and donor relationships	Hypothesis
9	Difficulty demonstrating measurable value to contributors	Hypothesis
10	Difficulty scaling partnership operations as participation grows	Hypothesis
11	Difficulty tracking community impact and communicating it effectively	Hypothesis
12	Difficulty maintaining equitable opportunities across the entire team	Potential strategic tension

Underlying Problem: How can WRTH scale its financial and community impact without proportionally increasing administrative work?

2. Student-Athletes — NIL Opportunities & Personal Branding

Context: Red Rocks gymnasts need ways to tell their stories, establish personal brands, attract sponsorships, and manage NIL opportunities while maintaining their academic and athletic commitments.

#	Problem	Status
13	Athletes need better ways to tell their personal stories	Challenge Objective
14	Athletes need to showcase accomplishments, interests, and personal brands	Challenge Objective
15	Athletes need more pathways to connect with sponsors	Challenge Objective
16	Athletes need ways to manage NIL opportunities	Challenge Objective
17	Athletes with smaller social media followings may receive less sponsor attention	Hypothesis
18	Athletic performance may overshadow community involvement or personal interests	Hypothesis
19	Athletes may lack experience marketing themselves professionally	Hypothesis
20	Athletes may struggle to determine which sponsorships fit their values	Hypothesis
21	Managing sponsorship deliverables alongside athletics and academics may be difficult	Hypothesis
22	Athletes may not know how to price or negotiate NIL opportunities	Hypothesis

23	Athletes may lack accessible performance or engagement data for sponsors	Hypothesis
24	Athletes may struggle to maintain consistent, high-quality promotional content	Hypothesis
25	Athletes may have difficulty understanding sponsorship restrictions and obligations	Hypothesis
26	Sponsor attention may disproportionately favor a few prominent athletes	Hypothesis

Underlying Problem: How do we make NIL opportunities accessible, meaningful, and manageable for every gymnast rather than only those with the largest audiences?

3. Fans & Alumni — Awareness, Conversion & Engagement

Context: Red Rocks Gymnastics has an established fanbase, but WRTH wants to increase the number of fans participating financially and create compelling reasons for continued engagement.

#	Problem	Status
27	Need to increase the number of fans contributing financially	Confirmed
28	Need to offer supporters meaningful value in return	Confirmed
29	Fans may not know WRTH exists or understand its mission	Hypothesis
30	Fans may not understand the differences between NIL support, charitable giving, and traditional donations	Hypothesis
31	Fans may be uncertain about how their money benefits athletes	Hypothesis
32	Fans may not see a compelling reason to become recurring subscribers	Hypothesis
33	Fans may lack personalized ways to connect with their favorite gymnasts	Hypothesis
34	Fans may want experiences rather than conventional membership benefits	Hypothesis
35	Fans may not see the community impact of their support	Hypothesis
36	Different supporter segments may need different participation options	Hypothesis
37	Contributions may not be connected to important fan engagement moments	Hypothesis
38	Supporters may not receive sufficiently engaging follow-up communication	Hypothesis

Underlying Problem: What transforms an enthusiastic Red Rocks fan into a committed and recurring financial supporter?

4. Businesses & Sponsors — Discovery, Matching & ROI

Context: WRTH wants to establish more business partnerships, but sponsors must understand how working with Red Rocks athletes creates measurable marketing, community, or brand value.

#	Problem	Status
39	WRTH needs to identify new business partners	Confirmed
40	Businesses need ways to connect with suitable athletes	Challenge Objective
41	Businesses may not know what NIL opportunities are available	Hypothesis
42	Smaller businesses may assume NIL sponsorships are unaffordable	Hypothesis
43	Businesses may struggle to identify athletes aligned with their brand	Hypothesis
44	Businesses may not understand the expected value of NIL partnerships	Hypothesis
45	Businesses may find sponsorship pricing and deliverables unclear	Hypothesis
46	Negotiating individual athlete partnerships may require too much effort	Hypothesis
47	Businesses may struggle to measure sponsorship performance	Hypothesis
48	Businesses may want community impact in addition to advertising exposure	Hypothesis
49	Businesses may not have clear pathways to propose partnerships	Hypothesis
50	Businesses may lack resources to create professional NIL campaigns	Hypothesis
51	Sponsors may find repeated relationships easier than discovering new athletes	Hypothesis

Underlying Problem: How can we make partnering with Red Rocks athletes attractive, understandable, and easy for businesses of different sizes?

5. Community Organizations — Partnerships & Impact

Context: WRTH promotes a Philanthro-Fan model that connects athlete financial opportunities with meaningful community activities and partnerships.

#	Problem	Status
52	WRTH wants to expand community-minded athlete opportunities	Confirmed
53	Community organizations may lack resources to coordinate athlete participation	Hypothesis
54	Nonprofits may struggle to discover appropriate athlete partners	Hypothesis
55	Matching athletes to causes they genuinely care about may be difficult	Hypothesis
56	Community events may require substantial coordination	Hypothesis
57	Community partners may struggle to demonstrate the impact of collaborations	Hypothesis
58	Sponsors may lack an easy way to participate in athlete-led community initiatives	Hypothesis
59	Athlete community work may receive less visibility than athletic accomplishments	Hypothesis

Underlying Problem: How can community participation become a repeatable, measurable part of NIL partnerships rather than a series of isolated events?

6. NIL Ecosystem — Trust, Fairness & Compliance

Context: WRTH emphasizes responsible NIL participation, supporting the entire gymnastics team, and avoiding purely transactional or exploitative arrangements.

#	Problem	Status
60	WRTH wants to avoid exploitative or purely transactional aspects of NIL	Confirmed
61	WRTH wants to support the whole team, not only individual stars	Confirmed
62	Fans may be skeptical about where NIL money goes	Hypothesis
63	Athletes and sponsors may find changing NIL rules confusing	Hypothesis
64	Partnership approvals and disclosure requirements may create friction	Hypothesis

65	Athletes may need protection from inappropriate sponsorship requests	Hypothesis
66	Using athletes' images, stories, and creative assets requires appropriate permissions	Design Consideration
67	Collecting athlete and sponsor information introduces data privacy responsibilities	Design Consideration
68	AI-based matching could reinforce popularity biases	Design Consideration
69	Different kinds of financial support may have different tax and legal treatment	Design Consideration
70	A platform that promises equitable exposure may conflict with sponsors' preference for reach	Strategic Tension

Underlying Problem: How can NIL growth remain trustworthy, athlete-centered, and compatible with WRTH's values?

7. Platform & Technology — Experience, Automation & Scalability

Context: A digital NIL platform could potentially reduce operational friction, improve discovery, and streamline athlete-sponsor relationships. However, existing workflows must be investigated before assuming inefficiencies.

#	Problem	Status
71	Athlete, sponsor, and opportunity information may be fragmented	Hypothesis
72	Discovering suitable athletes or sponsors may require manual research	Hypothesis
73	Partnership workflows may depend on emails and spreadsheets	Hypothesis
74	Matching athletes and brands may be time-intensive	Hypothesis
75	Creating personalized media kits may be time-consuming	Hypothesis
76	Partnership status and next steps may lack visibility	Hypothesis
77	Sponsors may need simpler onboarding and proposal processes	Hypothesis
78	Nontechnical users may find current NIL workflows difficult	Hypothesis
79	Different users may need distinct but connected experiences	Design Consideration
80	Scaling participation may increase administrative complexity	Hypothesis

Underlying Problem: Which steps in the existing NIL experience would benefit most from better design, automation, or AI?

8. Consolidated Root Problem Areas

The 80 individual problems can be grouped into eight major areas. These categories help us identify common causes rather than treating every symptom as an independent problem.

A. Awareness & Discovery

Core Problem: Potential supporters, sponsors, and athletes may have difficulty finding the right opportunities.

Affected Stakeholders: WRTH, fans, businesses, athletes.

Related Problems: 2, 3, 7, 15, 27, 29, 39, 40, 41, 49, 54, 72.

B. Conversion & Commitment

Core Problem: Interested supporters and businesses may lack sufficient motivation, clarity, or confidence to make financial commitments.

Affected Stakeholders: WRTH, fans, businesses.

Related Problems: 1, 4, 5, 6, 28, 30, 31, 32, 42, 44, 45.

C. Matching & Relevance

Core Problem: Identifying compatible athletes, sponsors, interests, and community causes may be inefficient or inconsistent.

Affected Stakeholders: Athletes, businesses, nonprofits, WRTH.

Related Problems: 17, 20, 26, 43, 48, 55, 58, 68, 70, 74.

D. Engagement & Retention

Core Problem: Supporters and sponsors may not receive enough ongoing value or personal connection to remain involved.

Affected Stakeholders: Fans, sponsors, WRTH.

Related Problems: 6, 9, 28, 32, 33, 34, 35, 36, 37, 38, 47, 51.

E. Operational Friction

Core Problem: Discovering, proposing, negotiating, coordinating, and tracking NIL opportunities may require excessive manual effort.

Affected Stakeholders: Athletes, WRTH, businesses.

Related Problems: 8, 10, 16, 21, 22, 25, 46, 49, 56, 64, 71, 73, 76, 77, 78, 80.

F. Storytelling & Differentiation

Core Problem: Athletes' personalities, accomplishments, interests, and community contributions may not be communicated effectively to potential supporters.

Affected Stakeholders: Athletes, sponsors, fans.

Related Problems: 13, 14, 18, 19, 23, 24, 33, 50, 59, 75.

G. Trust, Transparency & Impact

Core Problem: Supporters and sponsors may need clearer evidence of how their participation produces financial, athletic, and community value.

Affected Stakeholders: WRTH, fans, businesses, athletes, community organizations.

Related Problems: 9, 11, 30, 31, 35, 47, 57, 60, 62, 63, 65, 66, 67, 69.

H. Fair Access & Athlete Welfare

Core Problem: NIL participation may disproportionately benefit highly visible athletes or create additional burdens for athletes with fewer resources.

Affected Stakeholders: Athletes, WRTH.

Related Problems: 12, 17, 20, 21, 22, 26, 55, 60, 61, 65, 68, 70.

9. Preliminary Prioritization

This assessment considers relevance to the competition rubric and WRTH's stated business goals. It does not establish the actual severity of each problem.

Root Problem Area	Rubric Alignment	Business Relevance
A. Awareness & Discovery	High	High
B. Conversion & Commitment	Medium	Very High
C. Matching & Relevance	Very High	High
D. Engagement & Retention	Medium	High
E. Operational Friction	Very High	High
F. Storytelling & Differentiation	Very High	Medium–High
G. Trust, Transparency & Impact	Medium	High
H. Fair Access & Athlete Welfare	High	High

Preliminary Areas Worth Investigating

1. Conversion & Commitment (B)

Directly relates to WRTH's growth ambition. Understanding why supporters and businesses commit financially could reveal opportunities for meaningful revenue expansion.

2. Matching & Relevance (C)

Directly aligns with sponsor discovery, athlete profiles, AI innovation, and NIL opportunity creation. This area has strong competition relevance.

3. Operational Friction (E)

Directly aligns with the functional platform and NIL opportunity management requirements. Improving an existing workflow could create measurable practical value.

These are preliminary investigation priorities, not predetermined solutions.

10. Final Problem Discovery Questions

Before ideating, we should seek answers to the following questions:

1. What is the biggest obstacle preventing WRTH from increasing annual funding?
2. How does WRTH currently recruit and convert individual financial supporters?
3. How are new business sponsors identified, contacted, and onboarded?
4. Why do potential fans and businesses choose not to contribute?
5. What do current contributors receive, and what motivates them to continue?
6. How do gymnasts currently discover and manage NIL opportunities?
7. What steps in the athlete-sponsor partnership process require the most effort?
8. How does WRTH balance individual NIL opportunities with its team-wide philosophy?
9. What do sponsors consider valuable when evaluating a gymnast for a partnership?
10. Which of these problems could a functional digital platform realistically improve?

Conclusion

The competition presents a substantial opportunity to address real problems in the NIL ecosystem, but the existence and severity of most potential pain points remain unverified.

The strongest eventual solution should satisfy three conditions:

1. **Solve a meaningful problem:** Address an actual need experienced by WRTH, gymnasts, fans, or sponsors.
2. **Align with the judging criteria:** Demonstrate a functional NIL platform, athlete storytelling, sponsor engagement, AI innovation, and effective Adobe creative assets.
3. **Create practical value:** Improve a process, expand opportunities, or strengthen engagement in a way that can be demonstrated and potentially scaled.

Next Step: Validate and rank the most important problems before generating and evaluating product concepts.

Total Problems Identified: 80

Stakeholder/Problem Categories: 7

Consolidated Root Problem Areas: 8

Note: Confirmed items reflect the challenges and objectives described in the provided kickoff materials. Hypotheses and design considerations are analytical additions and should not be presented as findings from stakeholder research.